

No. 16 Lessons From the Land of Jesus (Symposium)—Phoenicia

PLEASE NOTE: Help viewers of the series The Good News According to Jesus to deepen their understanding of the locations and events depicted. This talk includes a video

WHAT HAPPENED IN PHOENICIA? (6 min.)

Let's start with a simple question: Where was Phoenicia located?

Phoenicia was a non-Israelite region located to the north of Israel along the Mediterranean Sea

Although Phoenicia is mentioned only 4 times in the Bible, you might recognize its two principle cities from your Bible reading:

Tyre and Sidon

The people of Phoenicia were descendants of some of the original Canaanites

And the region was known for its immoral pagan worship, including the very cruel practice of - child sacrifice

However, despite its pagan background, there were still some people who were genuinely interested in what Jesus taught.

In Mark chapter 3, we read that people from Tyre and Sidon were among the crowds who came to hear Jesus and be healed

And as we will see later, Jesus himself visited this region

Jesus also used the example of a humble Phoenician woman to make a very powerful point in Luke 4:25, 26

Let us now read those verses together

[Read Luke 4:25, 26]

(Luke 4:25, 26) For instance, I tell you in truth: There were many widows in Israel in the days of E-li'jah when heaven was shut up for three years and six months, and a great famine came on all the land. ²⁶ Yet E-li'jah was sent to none of those women, but only to a widow in Zar'e-phath in the land of Si'don.

Yes! Despite living in a city steeped in false worship, this Phoenician woman showed remarkable faith in Jehovah

When Elijah asked her to give up her very last meal, she obeyed without hesitation

What a spiritual gem in a place like Phoenicia!

To find out more about Phoenicia, let us watch the following video:

[2:15]

[Video crew begins video (3:45)]

The Great Isaiah Scroll—one of the oldest of the Dead Sea Scrolls and, at around 7 meters (23 ft), it's one of the longest. Yet, when Jesus stood to read from a similar scroll at the synagogue in Nazareth, he knew exactly where to find the portion of Isaiah he was looking for.

Jesus was thoroughly familiar with God's Word. That allowed him not only to declare good news from its pages but also to draw lessons from them, lessons which on that day in Nazareth provoked quite a response.

Truly I tell you that no prophet is accepted in his home territory.

For instance, . . . there were many widows in Israel in the days of Elijah when heaven was shut up for three years and six months, and . . . Elijah was sent to none of those women, but only to a widow in Zarephath in the land of Sidon.

Jesus was comparing the Nazarenes to the Israelites of Elijah's day who lacked faith. By contrast, the widow of Zarephath set a remarkable example of faith, especially when we consider where she was from. Zarephath was a town with close ties to Sidon. Sidon was one of several city-states in the coastal region to the north of Israel. Although they remained politically independent, in time they came to be known collectively as Phoenicia.

The Phoenicians were master craftsmen who built an empire of sorts, not by war or politics, but by trade all across the Mediterranean world. They were famed for their cedars, used in the construction of Solomon's temple, and even more so for their very expensive purple dye harvested from certain shellfish. Of course, mastering the seas was central to their vast trading network.

This artifact, excavated from Sidon, illustrates the reliance of these ancient seafarers on the power of the local storm god to control the weather. Also of note is a shrine dedicated to the pagan goddesses Astarte and Tanit, which was excavated in Zarephath itself. Although these finds are dated to before and after the widow's time, they help us to see that she lived in a place that for thousands of years was steeped in false worship. But in the midst of such a pagan culture, she put remarkable faith in Jehovah's prophet when most Israelites had not.

But would the people of Nazareth now do the same with the Prophet who stood in their midst, or would they reject him in his hometown? By using such a comparison, Jesus got right to his listeners' hearts. How they would respond was up to them.

LESSONS FROM PHOENICIA (3 min.)

What can we learn from this video?

Firstly, Jesus **recognized faith** - **wherever** it came from

In the video, Jesus was making a comparison between the **widow of Zarephath** and his **former neighbours** in Nazareth

The Nazarenes were familiar with the **messianic prophecy** and could have taken the **precious opportunity** to listen to Jesus and put faith in him

But instead, they were **more concerned** about the **miracles** that Jesus performed in **Capernaum**

They expected Jesus to also perform miracles **for their benefit**

So, Jesus exposed their **selfishness and lack of faith**

In contrast, the widow of Zarephath had **limited knowledge** of Jehovah and lived in a city **filled with false worship**

Yet, she exercised **remarkable faith** in Jehovah

What else can we learn from Jesus?

Let's look at an example in Matthew 15 when Jesus visited Phoenicia

In this account, a Phoenician woman came to Jesus, **begging** for him to **cure his demon possessed daughter**

Although Jesus did not respond immediately, the Phoenician woman **did not give up** and showed **humility and persistence**

So let's read Matthew 15:28 to see what Jesus did

(Matthew 15:28) Then Jesus replied to her: “O woman, great is your faith; let it happen to you as you wish.” And her daughter was healed from that hour on.

Yes! Jesus praised the great faith of this Phoenician woman and healed her daughter

What a beautiful example of how Jesus helped sincere people, no matter where they came from.

So, what can we learn from this talk?

Just like Jesus, we want to be keen observers of faith.

People we meet may come from very different religious, cultural, or social backgrounds

But when we look deeper, we may find a spark of genuine faith

Then let us seize the beautiful opportunity to nurture that spark of faith

Further, Jesus didn't let prejudice stop him from helping the Phoenician woman

He saw beyond backgrounds and focused on the heart

Similarly, let us be quick to provide practical assistance in our ministry

We are not out just sharing information, but our kind deeds can also help people grow in their faith of Jehovah

So as we go about our ministry, let's look out for these gems of faith in our territory

Let's be ready to recognize them, support them, and help them grow in their faith—just as Jesus did

[3:50]

Brother _____ will now present the final talk of this symposium, "Lessons From the Land of Jesus—Syria"